



Professor Nigel Healey
Vice Chancellor

Nai Raga

Weekly Message **Saptahik Samachar**

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To all members of Fiji National University

Bula! Last week began with a Senior Management Group (SMG) meeting that focused on a review of the University's research policies. My view has always been that you cannot *make* academic staff do a certain kind or quality of research. Rather the University needs to set research expectations (eg, through the academic promotions regulations or the performance management system) and then provide the support (time, resources) and incentives to encourage staff to produce good quality research. Or as the saying in academia goes, "Hire good people and give them the space and support to do good work".

We have already made significant improvements in the way we incentivise and support research. There are much clearer guidelines in terms of the research performance required for academic promotion and we have incentives in place to encourage staff to publish in leading, peer-reviewed journals. We launched new awards to celebrate research excellence and promising early-career researchers last year, which were awarded to staff at the December graduation ceremonies.

However, we still have weaknesses in our research policies. The system of approving funding for academic staff to attend conferences remains dysfunctional. As widely discussed last year, so-called "predatory conferences" are a growing problem in academia, with commercial conference organisers duping researchers and their sponsoring institutions into wasting scarce funds to attend bogus events.

Last Monday, SMG approved a new policy of devolving approval for conference attendance to colleges, while placing the onus on Deans and Associate Deans (Research) to check the quality of the conference at the start of the process, rather than this check falling on the Vice Chancellor at the end of the process, as at present. The changes should simplify the process and encourage more staff to present at national and international conferences.

Another area ripe for an overhaul is the way that the University funds research projects. Currently, there are dozens of projects that have been approved and funded in the past, but remain uncompleted or have funds that are still unacquitted. Most universities do not fund full research projects. Instead, they provide "pump-priming" to allow researchers to start the pilot phase and establish "proof of concept", so that they can subsequently bid for external research funding.

There are already a raft of external donors and agencies that fund research in the Pacific, and it seems likely that our Government will establish a Fiji Research Council to allocate research funding on a competitive basis. We need to support our researchers to become more successful in applying for external funding, rather than expecting the University to pick up the tab for every project. SMG accordingly approved a new research funding policy to close out many of the older, stalled projects and refocus funding on pump-priming new projects aimed at securing longer-term funding from external sources.

On Tuesday, we signed the contract to begin the construction of the new sports complex at Nasinu. At the signing ceremony, I emphasised that this project is part of a wider initiative to improve national wellness, by changing the behaviour of our staff and students and building recreational exercise into our daily lives. We know that Fijians are sports mad and that, as the national university, we need to provide much better facilities to allow our young people to train and excel at organised sports – rugby, soccer, basketball, netball, volleyball, etc. But we also know that many people stop exercising when they retire from competitive team sports. We need to find ways to keep them playing team sports at a recreational level, as well as making the transition to exercising regularly in the gym to retain their cardio-vascular health.

We have 20,000 students and if we can change their behaviour so that they continue to exercise regularly after they graduate, we will gradually change the course of the nation's health – by 2030, we will have 70,000 healthier graduates living and working in Fiji. We also have over 2,000 staff. If we can encourage many of them to return to regular exercise and promote their health, we can save many children from losing a parent to heart disease prematurely. At present, approximately one member of FNU staff dies in-service every month and the average age at which they die is just 51. We need to start tackling this problem.

Our new sports complex will be a fabulous facility for staff and students, a venue for organised sports events for teams in the central division and an iconic landmark building. But we also intend that it stands as a concrete expression of the University's commitment to push back against the pandemic of obesity and NCDs in Fiji and Pacific, by changing people's behaviour and improving their quality of life.

Finally, congratulations to the Fiji 7s team for a masterclass in the final at the Hamilton Rugby 7s, crushing USA 38-0. Another HSBC 7s championship title in 2019 and Olympic Gold in 2020 beckon!

Vinaka
Professor Nigel Healey
Vice Chancellor

Email: suggestions@fnu.ac.fj